

Announcements

Complete first draft of papers due this Saturday (Mar 1)

- no bullet points, all sections completed

Peer Feedback coming today

Poster comments/grades coming Thursday

Final paper, oral presentations start Mar 13, continue into finals week

Paper assignments

You MUST follow the template on Canvas for your paper!

These sections make a complete paper:

1. Title
2. Abstract
3. Introduction
4. Methods
5. Results
6. Discussion
7. Acknowledgements
8. References
9. Any tables and figures with captions

What questions do you have about your research paper?

The point of a first draft is not to get it right, but to get it written.

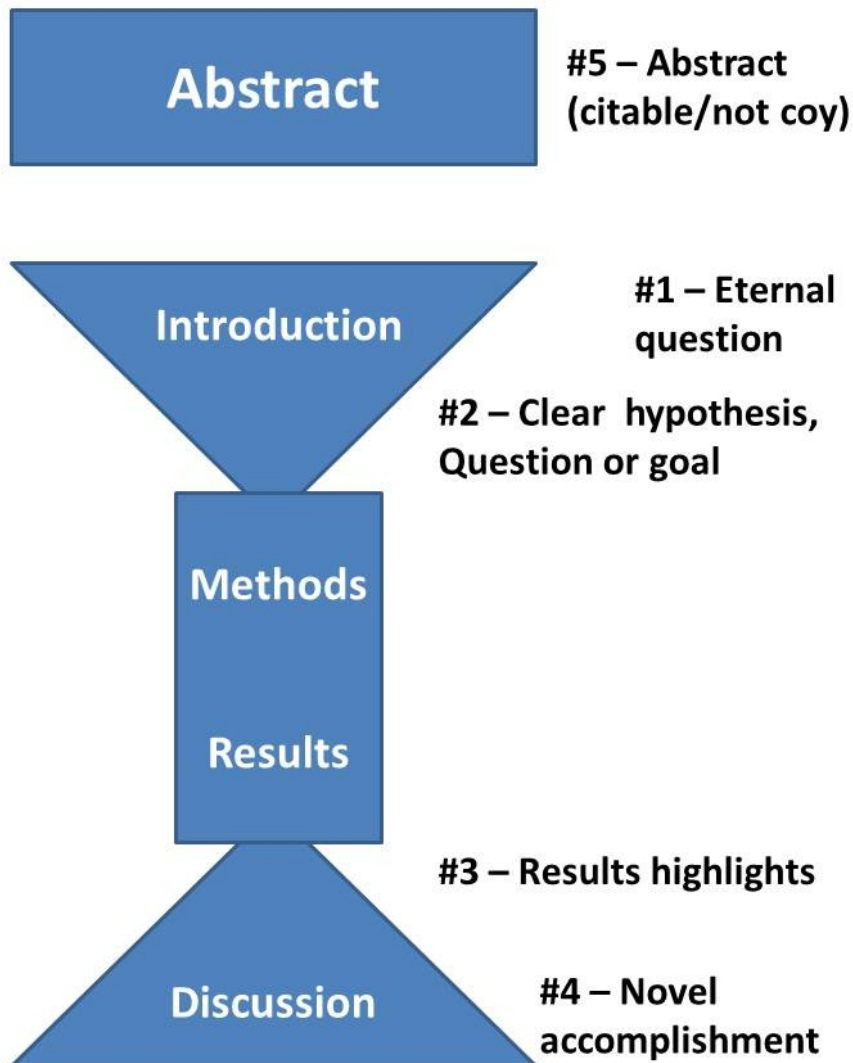
- It is way easier to edit existing writing than to write from scratch.
- Try to write something (anything) rather than leave things blank or bulleted.
- No, I will not judge you if your draft is not perfect. My first drafts are never perfect either.
- *We will* have time to edit drafts

The Abstract

Fish 290

Tuesday Feb 25

Recall paper structure and the 5 pivotal paragraphs



Now we are here



Good advice found here:

<https://dynamicecology.wordpress.com/2016/02/24/the-5-pivotal-paragraphs-in-a-paper/>

Most readers will only read three things:

1. Title
2. **Abstract**
3. Figures

Think: if the reader only sees these 3 sections, what do I want them to take away?

What is an abstract?

- An abstract is a brief summary of a study, with the purpose of helping the reader quickly ascertain the study's role
- From 150–300 words

What goes into an abstract?

An abstract should mimic the structure of the paper:

- 2-4 sentences giving background context
- Statement of objectives
- 1-2 sentences on overall approach to answering question, including key details like study site
- 2-3 sentences giving key results, in plain language
- 2-3 sentences giving interpretation and broader implications of key results

What goes into an abstract?

What **does not go** into an abstract:

- In-text citations
- Statistical details like a p-value
(however, sample sizes are easy enough to digest)

What makes an abstract successful?

The biggest mistake when writing the abstract is **being vague** or **hiding the key results**.

- Unlike a movie, there is no reason to avoid spoilers
- Each sentence in the Abstract is valuable and should have a purpose.
- Do not be vague (“Various results are shown.”)
- Do not simply start writing and stop when you hit 300 words.

Now on canvas

1. Using the template I just provided, let's break down published abstracts on Canvas.

Download 'abstracts to highlight.doc'

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